bag-head until he falls in love with a free-spirited woman and finds himself caught between the extremes of an oppressive regime and a liberatory paradise with no limits.

Shukla initially rolled out this story as a 14-minute short film in 2016. The global attention it drew motivated him to expand it to a feature-length production. "I have always been concerned with the rise and fall of civilisations," says the 39-year-old filmmaker. "Of late, political structures in many countries have been volatile. When I saw someone online draw similarities between my short film and the 2019-2020 Hong Kong protests, I realised the global appeal my story could have."

Schirkoa, an Indo-French-German production, features a global voice cast that includes Iranian star Golshifteh Farahani and French singer Soko. Shabaz Sarwar voices the protagonist 197A. Other voices include Denzil Smith, Asia Argento, Piyush Mishra and filmmakers Gaspar Noé, Lav Diaz, Anurag Kashyap, Shekhar Kapur and Karan Johar.

"I thought it would be ironical to have a voice as popular as Karan Johar's to be the announcer in a dystopian city," says Shukla. Though primarily in English, the city's inhabitants also speak in Hindi, Bengali, Gujarati, French, German and a host of languages, making Schirkoa a microcosm of the world itself.

Shukla animated his characters and the world using the Unreal Engine, which is primarily used to create video games. "Inside it, I can put my camera anywhere," says Shukla. He then used motion capture to accommodate real-life performances by his actors into his film. "I also tried to give the film a painterly feel, so that when we defocus, things start to smudge like watercolours," explains Shukla. "Plus, I have left slight outlines outside the characters, as if they are illustrations in a dated oil painting."



SHUKLA GOT SUCKED INTO THE WORLD OF ANIMATION AFTER WATCHING THE EXPERIMENTAL FILMS OF CHRIS LANDRETH

Gwalior-born Shukla, raised in Bhopal, grew up in an artistic household. He finished creating a 200-page Ramayana comic book by the age of nine. A career in engineering did not work out, and he got sucked into the world of animation after watching the experimental films of American animator Chris Landreth.

"So many young Indians actively interested in anime, manga and video games today give me hope that there is a space for artistic, thematically strong, homegrown animated films in our country," says Shukla. "The future is good." ■

–Devarsi Ghosh

forces a fragile, and often brutal, peace, and with the limits of its authority tested both by a constant flow of alien super-tech and by local warlords (and the gods forbid should the local warlords get hold of the alien super-tech!). Into this chaotic mix tumbles Lina and her monkey-bot brother, Bador. Lina dreams of bringing revolution to Shantiport, and make real the dreams of her father, a one-time dissident who was murdered by the Tiger Clan. Bador wants nothing more than to go off into space and have adventures. But when Bador recruits Moku—a story-bot with a mysterious past and even more mysterious capabilities—for Lina's secretive projects, things begin to escalate. Soon, the siblings are dragged into a hunt for a high-powered artefact, their own mother's plans for vengeance, romantic liaisons with the scion of the Tiger clan and an unexpected entanglement with the titular 'jinn' of the story, who—like any jinn—can grant three wishes, with the caveat that you must be *extremely* careful what you wish for.

Like Rushdie's Haroun and the Sea of Stories, The Jinn-Bot draws upon a variety of literary traditions

This motley crowd of characters bumping up against each other in the kaleidoscope of a novel that is *The Jinn-Bot of Shantiport* is reminiscent of some of the ludic qualities of Salman Rushdie's *Haroun and the Sea of Stories*. Like it, *The Jinn-Bot of Shantiport* draws upon a bewildering variety of literary and narrative traditions, picking at will from an extensive bouquet; while the unifying ur-text of *The Jinn-Bot of Shantiport* is the story of Aladdin—made clear through numerous intra-textual references—by the time the story is done, we have a hall of mirrors where steampunk Aladdin meets cyberpunk Aladdin meets AI Aladdin meets anime Aladdin, each with their own set of infinite reflections.

But that said, *The Jinn-Bot of Shantiport* is definitely an SF novel. Its overall tone—of tackling science-fictional themes involving artificial intelligence and sentience in the language and tropes of fantasy—is reminiscent of Robert Jackson Bennett's *Foundryside*; closer home, its world littered with the promises and ruins of technology brings to mind the novels of Saad Z. Hossain. And in keeping the political economy and social inequalities of the high-tech decaying city always at the forefront (without being didactic), the novel rubs shoulders with the progressive cutting-edge of contemporary SF, best exemplified in the works of Yoon Ha Lee or Max Gladstone. For long-time genre readers, this is a worthy addition to your bookshelves; for new readers, you could do worse than making this your gateway drug! ■

–Gautam Bhatia